THE COWARD KING

Game Design Document

Tactical Roguelite Board Game

José Abel Domínguez Rish - Leonardo André Flores Mendoza - Nicolás Casillas Larrañaga

Game Title	The Coward King
Genre	Roguelite Tactical Turn-Based Board Game
Platform	PC (Desktop)
Engine	Unity 2D / Godot 4
Target Audience	Strategy & roguelite fans, 12+
Team Size/Name	3 developers - Silent Crown
MVP Timeline	8 weeks
Document Status	Section 2: Game Design completed

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1. Index

This document covers the Game Design section (Section 2) of the GDD Template, as required for the partial submission. The following subsections are included:

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2. Game Design

2.1 Summary

Basic Game Description

The Coward King is a roguelite-style game that is highly tactical. It is played on a 6x6 board, which is very similar in size to a chessboard. The game centers on a king who is both the most powerful and the weakest at the same time; this is because he cannot defend himself directly, but instead uses a hand of cards to deploy allies and political traps on the board to protect himself. The objective of the game is for the king to survive 30 turns per horde without sustaining a single scratch, and to ensure that no more than two enemies enter the king's safe zone—which is 3x3—at the same time.

This game will have three levels, each featuring several hordes and a final boss. This adds up to a total of twelve encounters per battle. As in a good roguelite, if the king takes damage and dies, the player will return to the same level where the king died, retaining their permanent rewards purchased with the gold earned by defeating hordes and clearing levels, which are preserved after deaths.

Design Model: Roguelite

- Permanent upgrades: the player loses gold on death but retains purchased card upgrades.
- Checkpoint system: death in Level 2 returns the player to Level 2 Horde 1, not to the very beginning. Progress is fair, so is the player .
- Randomized card hand: 3 random cards are dealt each horde from a pool of 12, creating variation between runs without requiring procedural level generation.
- Short sessions: each horde lasts a maximum of 30 turns (~5-10 minutes). The full game takes 1-3 hours. This matches the roguelite principle of short, repeatable sessions.
- "One more run" loop: the combination of random hands, permanent upgrades, and visible unlockable improvements creates the compulsive loop characteristic of this genre.

2.2 Gameplay

Objective

Victory (per horde): Survive 30 turns without the king being touched by an enemy AND without 2 or more enemies simultaneously entering the 3x3 safe zone around the king.

Defeat: The king is touched by an enemy OR 2 or more enemies occupy the 3x3 safe zone at the same time.

Full game victory: Complete all 3 levels (3 hordes + 1 boss each) = 12 total encounters defeated.

Level Structure

Level 1	Skeleton King — 3 hordes (basic skeletons) + Skeleton King boss
Level 2	Ogre — 3 hordes (tougher ogres) + Ogre boss
Level 3	Brave King — 3 hordes (elite fast warriors) + Brave King boss (final)
Checkpoint rule	Death in Level 2 Horde 2 restarts from Level 2 Horde 1, NOT Level 1
On death	Retain purchased card upgrades; lose unspent gold
Level complete	Auto-save. Session can be closed and resumed.

The Game Board (6x6)

The board is arranged in a 6-row by 6-column grid, much like a chessboard, with a total of 36 squares. The contents of the squares may be as follows:

- The King (exactly 1 at all times)
- An ally unit (Knight, Archer, Mage, etc.)
- An enemy unit
- A political card / trap (Exile, Royal Decree, etc.)
- Empty space

The king starts in the center of the board, and its 3x3 safe zone is dynamic and moves along with the king. Enemies spawn on the opposite side of the board, around row 0 or 5, with random columns, and advance one square toward the king on each of their turns. It is important to note that 3 enemies will appear on each turn.

Turn System

Phase 1 — Player	Choose ONE main action: play cards (spend AP) OR move the king. Upgrading cards does NOT consume a turn.
Phase 2 — Enemies	All enemies move 1 tile toward the king. Ally units auto-attack if an enemy is in range.
Turn limit	Maximum 30 turns per horde. Surviving 30 turns = automatic victory of that horde.
AP accumulation	Unspent Action Points carry over between turns with no cap.

Player Actions (choose ONE per turn)

- Play Card(s): Spend Action Points to summon units or place traps. Multiple cards can be played in one turn if enough AP is available. Cannot place on occupied tiles.
- Move the King: The king moves like a chess king — 1 tile in any of 8 directions. Cannot move to tiles occupied by allies or enemies. The safe zone moves with him.
- Upgrade Cards (special, no turn cost): Can be done at any point during the player's turn. Costs gold (20-50 per upgrade). Upgrades are PERMANENT across deaths.

Resource System

Starting AP	5 per horde
AP carryover	Unused AP accumulates between turns (no limit)
AP bonus	+5 AP upon winning a horde, applied to next horde
Card cost range	1 to 5 AP depending on card power
Gold income	10 gold per horde victory
Gold use	Permanent card upgrades: 20–50 gold each
Gold on death	Unspent gold is lost. Purchased upgrades are kept.

Card System - Hand Mechanics

- At the start of each horde: receive 3 random cards from the pool of 12.
- Upon winning a horde: receive 3 new random cards + keep 1 card from the previous hand (player chooses which).
- Maximum hand size: 4 cards (3 new + 1 carried over).
- Played cards do not return to hand until the next horde.

Full Card Pool (12 Cards)

Card	Type	Cost (AP)	Stats	Effect
Knight	Attack Unit	3	80 HP / 30 DMG	Melee. Moves toward nearest enemy, attacks when adjacent.
Archer	Attack Unit	2	50 HP / 20 DMG	Ranged (3 tiles). Stationary. Auto-attacks nearest in range.
Mage	Attack Unit	4	40 HP / 25 DMG	AoE cross pattern (3 tiles), range 2. Fragile but powerful.
Pikeman	Attack Unit	2	60 HP / 15 DMG	Fast (2 tiles/turn). Intercepts quick enemies.
Wall	Defense Unit	3	150 HP / 0 DMG	Blocks tile. Enemies must destroy or go around.
Squire	Defense Unit	2	70 HP / 10 DMG	Reduces 50% damage to adjacent allies. Moves 1 tile/turn.
Tower	Defense Unit	4	100 HP / 35 DMG	Ranged (4 tiles). Stationary. Auto-attacks in range.
Guardian	Defense Unit	3	120 HP / 25 DMG	Tanky mobile unit. Moves 1 tile/turn. Absorbs high damage.
Exile	Political	2	—	Trap: enemy stepping on this tile is paralyzed for 2 turns.
Royal Decree	Political	3	—	3x3 push zone: enemies pushed 1 tile back each turn.
Peace Treaty	Political	2	—	3x3 slow zone: enemies move at 50% speed (1 tile per 2 turns).
Royal Curse	Political	4	—	3x3 debuff zone: enemies deal 50% less damage for 5 turns.

Enemy Stats by Level

Level	Enemy	HP	Damage	Speed	Notes
Level 1	Skeleton	50	15	1 tile/turn	Basic. Easy to intercept.
Level 2	Ogre	80	25	1 tile/turn	Tougher. Requires stronger units.
Level 3	Elite Warrior	100	35	2 tiles/turn	Fast. Bypasses slow defenses.
Boss 1	Skeleton King	200	30	Special	Spawns skeletons. Advances only when ally dies.

Level	Enemy	HP	Damage	Speed	Notes
Boss 2	Ogre	350	40	Special	Spawns ogres. Same summon mechanic, harder.
Boss 3	Brave King	500	50	Special	Spawns elite warriors. Final challenge.

Boss Mechanic

All bosses share the same summoning cycle pattern:

- At combat start, the boss summons 1 normal enemy in an adjacent tile.
- While the summoned ally is alive, the boss does NOT move.
- The summoned ally advances toward the king normally.
- When the ally dies, the boss advances 1 tile toward the king.
- After advancing, the boss summons another ally. Cycle repeats until boss dies or reaches the king.

2.3 Mindset

In this section, we outline our five core emotions, which will guide every decision in the game design process. Every decision can be justified by a specific mechanic that brings it to life.

1. Constant Tactical Tension

Each turn will present complex challenges and force the player to make difficult decisions:

Should you save up action points to use later when the game gets more complex and there are more powerful cards, or deploy a unit right away?

Should you stick to your current strategy by keeping the king in position, or risk everything and move him? All of this comes at the risk of your 3x3 safety zone, as it can create constant anxiety—when two enemies approach at the same time, it can trigger a sense of paranoia or panic.

Additionally, as a game mechanic, there is a defeat condition involving the safety zone: if two enemies are inside it, with a limit of one action per turn, and these enemies advance aggressively each turn.

2. Satisfaction of the Perfect Plan

When the player places a wall, they will trigger a royal decree that pushes back three enemies in a single move, or saves up action points over several turns to deploy a tower and a mage at the same time, creating an extraordinary experience. This will allow the player to see their strategy unfold on the game board.

From a design perspective, it is essential to provide a complete view of the board; this will help players gain a comprehensive overview so they can make the best decisions, allowing political cards, area-effect cards, and point accumulation to make more sense and function as rewards earned through strategy and patience.

3. Strategic Cowardice (Not Humiliating)

The king flees and never attacks; all of this could be interpreted as cowardice or simple shame, but that is not the case. The king uses his power to defend himself, employing his political influence and his subjects to stay alive. So this can also be seen as cunning; that’s why the player acts as the mastermind behind the entire game, since they must implement different strategies to keep the king alive, making smart moves rather than weak ones.

In terms of design mechanics, the king will be depicted in pixel art. He will be portrayed with comical expressions to generate more interest in the game; for example, his faces and various expressions, such as looking scared yet maintaining a dignified appearance. Additionally, the

king will be animated, with his cape visible as it moves (fluttering) while he runs. Finally, a touch of humor and irony will be added to the political cards (Exile, Royal Decree, and Peace Treaty).

4. Learning Through Repetition

Since this is a strategy game, it's important to learn from your mistakes, so every death can teach you something different and important. "I should have used Exile sooner," "Next time, it would be better to place the tower first instead of last." That's why the point system is essential, as it allows you to try again without having spent or lost all your progress. This helps ensure that permanent upgrades create a sense of progress, rather than the frustration of having to start all over from scratch.

Therefore, the game mechanics will feature checkpoints per level, noting that these are NOT per wave—where permanent card upgrades are earned and where waves are short, lasting a maximum of 30 turns, which is about 5 to 10 minutes.

5. One More Run (Healthy Addiction)

One of the things that will make each attempt different is the three random cards the player receives in each wave. This prompts the player to consider how best to manage these cards. For example: "Right now I have the mage and the tower, so I can try a strategy of defending the king from a distance," where later upgrades might tempt the player. E.g., "My knight is now going to deal +2 damage, so I'm going to try it out."

In terms of game mechanics, each hand is random and specific to each wave, where players have the option to keep one card across waves to develop strategies for future waves. On top of all this, an upgrade system will be implemented, showcasing the various items that can be unlocked.

2.4 Roguelite and Trading Card Game Elements

Roguelite Elements

Roguelite Feature	Implementation in The Coward King
Permanent progression	Card upgrades (+damage, +HP, -cost) purchased with gold survive death. Each run is stronger than the last.
Checkpoint system	Death resets to the start of the current level, not the entire game.
Randomized runs	3 random cards dealt each horde from a pool of 12. Different builds emerge each run.
Short session loop	Each horde lasts a maximum of 30 turns. The game is designed for repeated short attempts.
Meaningful failure	Death always teaches a lesson. The game shows why you lost (king touched / safe zone breach / boss).
Meta-progression	Gold and upgrades accumulate across deaths until spent, creating a long-term power curve.

Trading Card Game Elements

TCG Feature	Implementation in The Coward King
Hand management	Player holds 3-4 cards per horde, must decide when to play each one. Played cards don't return until next horde.
Card pool & randomness	12 total cards in the pool. 3 random cards dealt per horde, creating variable strategies.
Resource cost system	Action Points (1-5 per card) mirror the mana/energy system of TCGs. AP accumulates if not spent.
Card retention choice	Between hordes, the player keeps 1 card from their previous hand — a deck-building decision.
Card upgrade / crafting	Permanent upgrades (+damage, +HP, -cost) mirror card enhancement in TCGs and CCGs.
Synergy potential	Combining cards (e.g., Wall + Tower, Exile + Mage) creates powerful combos that reward strategic thinking.

2.5 Visual Style

Art Direction

Coward King will feature a pixel art aesthetic, using 16x32-pixel sprites to create units and keep the board clean. The visual style we aim for is a comical medieval look, where the king appears exaggeratedly frightened (with wide-open eyes and his cape billowing in the wind) and the enemies have a cartoonish, not entirely threatening style.

Art style	Pixel art, 16x16 and 32x32 sprites
Board style	Checkerboard with alternating neutral tones (light gray / cream). Safe zone highlighted in soft green.
Color palette	Muted medieval palette: stone grays, forest greens, parchment yellows, deep reds for enemies.
Animation	2-4 frames per unit (idle + attack/move). King has: idle, run (fleeing), celebrate, panic.
UI style	Card game UI — cards displayed as rectangles with icon, name, cost, and description. Clean sans-serif font.
Tone	Comedic but readable. Humor through the king's expressions, not through chaotic visuals.
References	Slay the Spire (card UI), Into the Breach (board clarity), Dicey Dungeons (character expression).

Visual Justification

Using pixel art for this video game is essential, and this can be explained by the following three reasons:

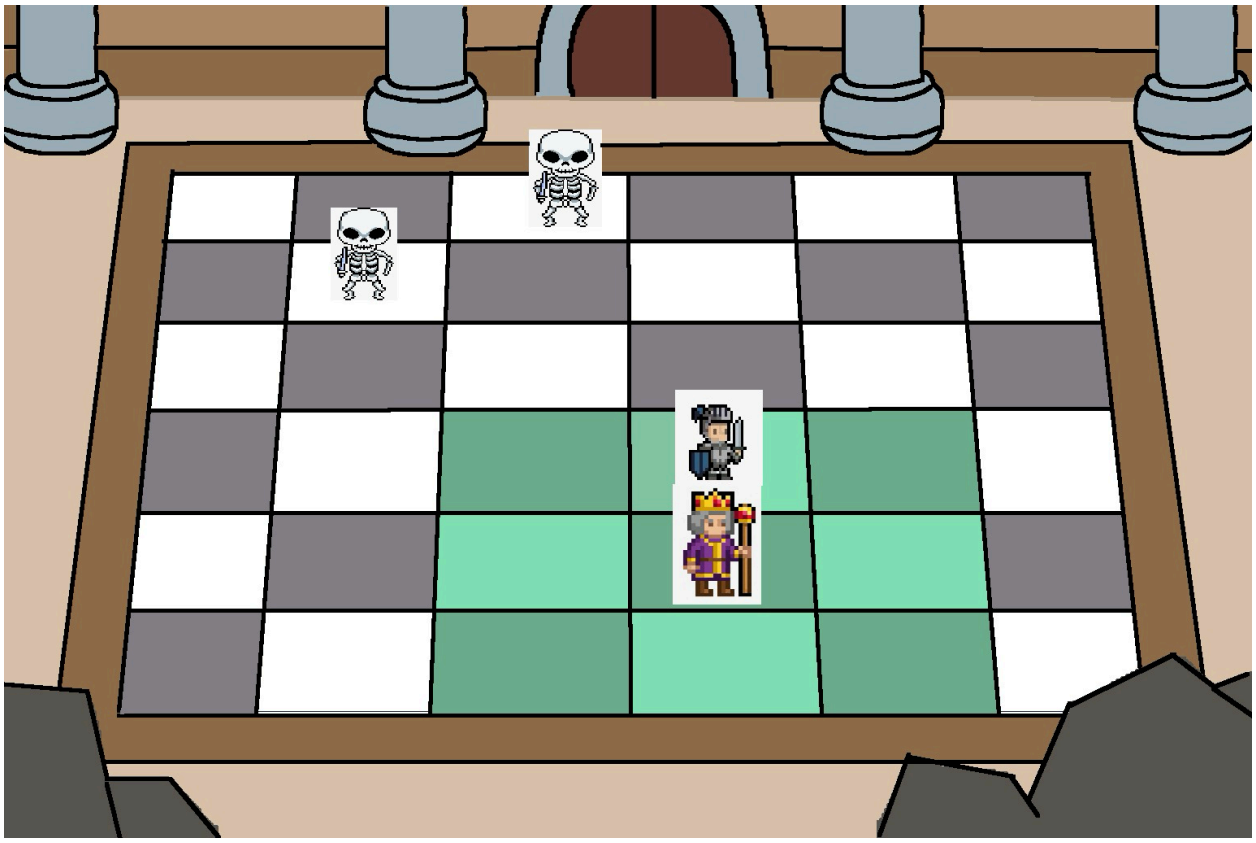
- The team consists of three members, none of whom are experienced artists, so by using pixel art and 16x32 sprites, we can work with tools like Asperite. On the other hand, since we have limited resources, we can use free temporary resources like Kenney.nl, which allows us to continue development even before all the graphic assets are finished.

- In terms of readability, using pixel art greatly helps maintain clarity on the grid/board where the game is played. This is because it makes it easier to distinguish characters or objects by their silhouette alone. This would also enhance gameplay and tactical agility by making things easier to see; analysis could be done more quickly.

- Finally, there is the harmony of tones: using pixel art supports the medieval mechanical aesthetic the video game aims to achieve. The king’s exaggerated expressions work better here than they would with realistic or vector-based scales.

Visual for the Board

A 6x6 board (similar a as a chess board), where enemies and allies will be deployed.
Allies will be represented as a pixel art knight and enemies as skeletons. There will be different types of enemies, this image is for representation of the concept only.



Allies and Enemies

2.5 References

Imagen 1 Into the Breach

Imagen 2 Sly the spire

Imagen 3 Dungeon of Endless

Our game was inspired by other titles such as Into the Breach, Slay of Spire, and Dungeon of the Endless. These games are similar in that they combine turn-based tactics on a board where every decision and deployment is of utmost importance; therefore, the use of cards is essential for developing tactics across different matches. They also share a survival mode where players face waves of enemies in open-ended environments. On the other hand, we also aim for roguelite elements and replayability through these decisions, where there are changing configurations and situations within a fixed structure. All of this aligns with how our game's design is described.